Spot the Strain in Your Husband's Care Before It Becomes a Crisis

Four prompts to look at your own week honestly, find the tasks no one has quite agreed to, name the conversation you've been putting off, and leave with the family's stress points on one page.

Where you are

You look after your husband, and it works, more or less. The kids help when they can. But the list of things you do has grown without anyone deciding it should, and there's a conversation with your daughter you keep not having.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say what has gotten harder, point to the tasks that are nobody's job in particular, and raise one difficult subject with the family while it is still a conversation rather than an emergency.

A one-page stress-points sheet with four headings: What Is Getting Harder, Where Nobody Is Sure Who Does It, The Conversation to Have Soon, and What We Will Watch.

Before you start

- A rough list of what you do for your husband in a typical week.
- The tasks you think the kids or anyone else handles.
- The thing you haven't said to the family, even if you haven't put it into words yet. One of these is enough to begin.

PROMPT 1

Look at your own week honestly

WHY THIS MATTERS

Caregiving grows quietly. A year ago you didn't manage his pills or drive him everywhere, and now you do, and it feels normal because it arrived one task at a time. Writing the week down lets you see its real size.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of what you do for him in a typical week, including the things that don't feel like care.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I look after my husband at home. Here is everything I can think of that I do for him in a typical week, including small things:

> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Turn it into a table with columns: TASK, HOW OFTEN, ROUGHLY HOW LONG, and NEW OR CHANGED IN THE LAST YEAR (yes, no, or not sure). Add up a rough weekly total of hours. Then write two short lists: tasks that only I know how to do, and tasks I do at night or early in the morning. Don't comment on whether the total is too much. Just show me the week as it is.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The weekly total, and how many rows say 'new or changed this year.'

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the table to one person you trust and ask whether it looks like your week to them.

PROMPT 2

Find the tasks nobody has quite agreed to

WHY THIS MATTERS

In a family arrangement, half the work happens because someone assumed someone else would do it, or because one person stopped waiting. Those tasks are the ones that get missed when a week goes wrong.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The tasks that other people handle, or that you think they handle.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the things that need to happen for my husband that I don't do myself, or that I'm not sure who does:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Sort every task into three columns: CLEARLY SOMEONE'S JOB, where I named a person and we've actually agreed; ASSUMED BUT NEVER DISCUSSED, where I named a person but we've never talked about it; and NOBODY'S JOB YET. For each item in the second and third columns, write one plain sentence I could use to ask about it without it sounding like a complaint. Don't tell me which gaps are most serious.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much ends up in the middle column. Assumed-but-never-discussed is where arrangements fray.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Use two of the plain sentences this week, with whoever they're for.

PROMPT 3

Name the conversation you've been putting off

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most families have one subject that nobody raises: a son who promised more than he delivers, a disagreement about whether he should still drive, a daughter who thinks everything is fine. The longer it waits, the harder it gets, and the more likely it is to come out badly.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A few honest lines about the subject, written only for yourself.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> There is a conversation about my husband's care that I've been avoiding with my family. Here is what it's about, in my own words, including the parts I'm not proud of:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Help me get ready for it. First, state the issue in one or two plain sentences, built around what my husband needs rather than what anyone did wrong. Second, give me three different ways I could open the conversation, each one short and calm. Third, list what I would want to have agreed by the end of it, as two or three concrete things. Don't write the rest of the conversation for me, and don't take sides.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

An opening line you could actually say out loud.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick a time and a person, and set the conversation up for sometime in the next two weeks.

PROMPT 4

Put the stress points on one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

One honest page, written while things are still working, is worth more than a long conversation after they stop. It also makes it acceptable to ask for help, because the asking is already on paper.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The three results you have so far.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've put together about how my husband's care arrangement is holding up:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF YOUR FIRST THREE PROMPTS]
>
> Write a one-page sheet for my family with four headings: WHAT IS GETTING HARDER, WHERE NOBODY IS SURE WHO DOES IT, THE CONVERSATION TO HAVE SOON, and WHAT WE WILL WATCH. Under the last heading, list four or five ordinary signs, taken from my notes, that would tell us the arrangement is getting harder than it looks, such as a task being skipped two weeks running. Keep the tone matter of fact, not alarming. Finish with one line that says how a family member can raise a new concern, which I will fill in.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page you'd be willing to hand your daughter without an argument.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Share it before the next family visit, and bring it with you to the next step below.

Turn your page into the family's starting file.

The stress points you've written down are a piece of a larger picture. The care interview asks about your husband's whole situation, in order, and gives the family a Family Care Profile to come back to as his needs and your capacity change.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›